

No Bar on Beauty

■ By Dr Anjali Chhabria



Six year old Diya's secret ambition is to be Miss Universe and she has already started counting calories. At a recent birthday party, a couple of nine-year-

olds were overheard discussing whether they were looking fat and how they should start exercising. Recently I had eight-year-old Aishwarya who was brought to me by her worried mother for shaving her upper lip as she was embarrassed and fed up about her hair growth. Shocking, but unfortunately that is the sad state of our urban Indian kids today. The age for beauty and beauty treatments is going down. The first newspaper that our children pick up in the morning is the coloured section which highlights the latest fashions and showcases the hep and happening crowd. How our children would love to be on that page! Glamour attracts the new generation and the impact of media is most influential. A lot of kids today would love to be actors and models rather than doctors and lawyers as these are the professionals who get to party, make a lot of money, wear good clothes and be on the cover of magazines. And it's so easy. All you have to do is look 'pretty and thin'.

When eight to ten year old girls were asked to draw themselves, the figures drawn are petite and stylish, with eyelashes emphasised, narrow waist and long legs. Children learn best with imitation and do we have only the media and beauty contests to blame? A quick look around reveals that behind these girls it is often their mothers who are obsessed with their looks and weight. No wonder then that diet and gym is the new 'mantra' for many women and a lot of

kids follow suit. "Thin is in" but do we realise the damage that we do to a young child's mind by constantly emphasising how fat he or she has become? Anorexia and bulimia are on the rise in India and go unidentified for years together till complications strike.

Fashion also dominates today's teens and pre-teens. They are more 'brand conscious' and spend a lot of money and time in 'looking good' and 'fitting in'. I often come across young kids who feel they are not good enough

are unable to create an understanding that "beauty is not skin deep".

Are we, as a society, encouraging adults who look like 'dudes' but lack self confidence once they are stripped off their brands? What happens to contestants who lose beauty contests? It is unfortunate that lakhs of rupees are spent on grooming them physically but not a thought is given to their mental health. As a result, many go through despair and depression but unfortunately that does not make headlines. It

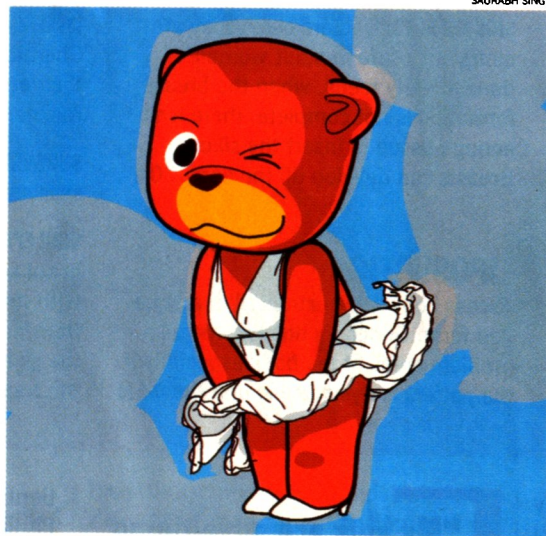
is high time we give more importance to grooming well-rounded personalities rather than creating banks of superficial, selfish, self-obsessed human beings.

Adolescence is a crucial phase wherein it is natural to be preoccupied with looks but self-obsession reveals disturbances and distortions. Children going through emotional concerns with looks create a roadblock to their personality. They show warning signs like repeatedly looking in the mirror; finding irrational faults in the way they look; concern with weight, dieting and exercise; anxiety due to body image; low self esteem and withdrawal from their natural environment.

Parents can prevent as well as deal with such concerns by not using negative statements about the gender, colour, height and weight of the child. Encouraging skills and abilities, healthy eating habits and an emotionally comfortable atmosphere help foster

healthy self esteem. However, if the child is going through a phase where his body image is affecting his personality, it is important to seek help from a psychiatrist/psychologist to deal with the issues. Looks can be deceptive. Let's not focus on the outer beauty but have an inner makeover instead!

The author is a Mumbai-based consultant psychiatrist and psychotherapist.



SAURABH SINGH

Glamour attracts the new generation and they would love to be actors and models instead of doctors and lawyers.

because they do not belong to the 'hep group'. Sadly, it seems more important to be 'sexy and hot' rather than 'smart and intelligent'. Money, the most necessary evil, is to be spent today on accessories rather than necessities.

Are we, as 'shining India', bringing up a bunch of kids who are only concerned with external beauty? Maybe the situation is not so bleak but definitely a matter of concern if we adults